ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Four Worlds of Prayer: Climbing Up and Coming Down

Derech Hashem 4:6:13-14

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 6, paragraphs 13-14 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 24 March 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are

The Rabbi recalled the four categories of misvot (daily, seasonal, circumstantial and constant) and the daily ones covered so far: washing the hands, sisit, tefillin and the four parts of prayer. In the last class the first and last three blessings of the Amidah were linked to the three letters of God's name and the three main Sefirot, Hesed, Gevurah and Tiferet. Now, he said, "we get into the basics of Kabbalah."

Four worlds (paragraph 13)

The Ramhal describes four worlds:

1. The lowest is this world, which has two parts: the celestial (stars and planets) and the terrestrial, planet Earth. "Don't think stars and planets are a different world"; together they are one world.
2. Above it is the world of the angels, who carry things out.
3. Above that is the world of the highest forces, the roots and sources of all existence, discussed in Part 1: everything here has a root, and the root is found there.
4. Highest of all are the different influences and lights from which the roots themselves come.

The Rabbi gave the names used in Kabbalah, hinted at in Yeshayahu's verse "Everyone called by My name, for My glory, I created him, I formed him, I also made him": Asilut (the glory), Beriah, Yesirah and Asiyah. Asiyah is the world of action, which includes everything physical, even the distant stars. He added the image from the Gemara that there is no painter like Hakadosh Barukh Hu: there is the vision, and then the brush strokes that actually bring it into being.

So the chain runs from the top: the light of Hakadosh Barukh Hu, "if we can talk like that", becomes manifest in the roots of things; the roots translate into angels; and the angels act in the physical world we live in.

Why the top "world" is only borrowed language

The Ramhal says the names of the lower three worlds are precise, but calling the fourth a "world" is only a manner of speaking. Why?

A world is a gathering of many different components that relate to one another. Human beings and planets interact, so they form a world. The angels, each with its role, form a world. The roots and sources of all the energies form a world. But the light of Hakadosh Barukh Hu is not a collection of different entities, "has veshalom, that's a denial of Yihud Hashem." God is one; there are no different lights.

It only looks to us like different lights. The Rabbi repeated an analogy he has used before: the sun's light seen through brown sunglasses looks brown, through red glasses red, through green glasses green. It is the same light, but each receiver experiences it differently. So sometimes God appears to us as kindness, sometimes as strictness, sometimes as compassion, and so it seems like a world of different lights. "It's all one. It comes down to us as different."

A participant asked whether the lower three worlds are finite. The Rabbi agreed: if this world is finite, the worlds of the angels and the roots, which reflect it, are finite too, while calling the highest a "world" would wrongly make it finite. The participant suggested it is singular yet infinite, and the Rabbi agreed: "singular, but it's infinite."

Prayer climbs the worlds (paragraph 14)

Why does the Ramhal tell us all this here? Because prayer is divided according to the four worlds. "When we are praying, we are ascending worlds."

Going up:

- **Korbanot** correspond to the lowest world: doing, the physical, slaughtering.
- **Pesukei DeZimra** correspond to the world of the angels.
- **The blessings of Shema**, which speak of all the different levels, correspond to the third world, the source of everything.
- **The Amidah** corresponds to the fourth and highest world. "You can't just jump up and ask." Once you begin the Amidah you are in the top world for all of it.

Coming down, three more stages bring the energy drawn in the Amidah down bit by bit:

- **Ashrei** (Tehillah LeDavid) for the third world.
- **The Shir shel Yom**, the Levites' song, for the second world.
- **Ein Kelohenu** for the lowest world.

Then comes **Alenu**, the finale: after everything has been brought down, we declare that Hakadosh Barukh Hu is One.

Kaddish and Tahanun

This explains why there is a Kaddish between each world. A participant noticed there is none between the blessings of Shema and the Amidah; the Rabbi agreed that this is because one may not interrupt there.

He then asked: where does Tahanun fit? It is part of the Amidah: the Amidah is the standing part and Tahanun the sitting part. That is why there is no Kaddish between them and why, as the halachah says, one may not speak from Barekhu until after Tahanun. Once Tahanun is finished, you have left the top world and may speak freely. "You don't realise, Tahanun is part of the Amidah."

Praying in order

A participant pointed out that people who skip parts and say them afterwards are mixing up the order. The Rabbi agreed, comparing it to getting dressed in the wrong order. And if a person says the first parts without real concentration, he limits how high he can climb.

He acknowledged the halachic tension. Some say the order is Kabbalah, but the halachah is to pray the Amidah with the minyan, so one should skip in order to keep up. He himself prefers to pray in order, even alone, rather than jump and skip, but he understands those who choose the minyan. "Whatever you do, it's important to be consistent." And best of all, start on time.

The next class will finish the chapter, going through other parts of the prayer such as the viduy.

Summary

- There are four worlds: our physical world, the world of the angels, the world of the roots, and the highest level of divine lights.
- The names Asilut, Beriah, Yesirah and Asiyah are hinted at in a verse in Yeshayahu.
- Only the lower three are truly "worlds"; God's light is one and only appears to us as many, like sunlight through coloured glasses.
- Prayer climbs the worlds (korbanot, Pesukei DeZimra, the blessings of Shema, the Amidah) and then brings the energy down (Ashrei, the Shir shel Yom, Ein Kelohenu), ending with Alenu.
- Kaddish divides the worlds; Tahanun is part of the Amidah; praying in order matters.

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